

held devices provide a glimpse into the metaverse as a new destination for entertainment. “Affordable data plans and smartphone penetration have opened up new opportunities for consumers and creators. That has led to the proliferation of digital platforms and a surge in consumption.”

Clearly, the emergence of a digital ecosystem has been the biggest catalyst of this transformation. Vivek Menon, Managing Partner at NV Capital, a media and entertainment (M&E) credit fund, says all M&E businesses have a digital presence now. “That will drive a successful business model. Another key disruption is the rise of social media, short-form snacky content and gaming platforms, which have grown exponentially over the last five years.”

Amidst all this, one has a very selective consumer, and not without reason. The pandemic ensured that she was exposed to content across genres and languages. “The big lesson is that the audience will not settle for average content... If the content is good, they will pay for it,” says Shibasish Sarkar, Chairman & CEO, International Media Acquisition Corp. People in the multiplex business maintain that the consumption of cinema will also continue to be on a high-growth trajectory. “Consumers will continue to watch it [cinema] regardless of the platform. One has to understand that the emergence of OTT as an alternate distribution channel is purely a result of the pandemic and not about the inability of the multiplexes to draw crowds. All entertainment options in India will co-exist, since each has a distinct appeal,” insists Alok Tandon, CEO of Inox Leisure, a pan-India multiplex chain.

Of course, more options on digital come with their own set of complications. The heterogeneity of programming means tastes within a home will inevitably vary. Ac-

cording to Vikram Mehra, MD of content major Saregama India, in the current decade, “it is perfectly okay for different members of the family to watch different content on different devices, even if they are sitting in the same room. This has had a massive impact on the entire content ecosystem in terms of what content we create, how we promote that content or how we make money from that content, among other things.” The concept of on-demand content, he explains, has put massive pressure on content creators to up their game. “Obviously, a presence on prime time is no longer a crutch that one can rely on.”

The exposure to global content, thinks N.P. Singh, MD & CEO of Sony Pictures Networks India (SPN), has resulted in the emergence of a mature audience with an appreciation for sophisticated content. “By itself, content has come a long way; from mass production to now catering to a broad audience to storylines plus the entire viewing experience is personalised and tailored to different consumer segments. In this regard, the media companies have not only made wise content choices but also improved the overall viewing experience thanks to superior user interface and services across platforms.”

Globally, gaming is a bigger business than film production. Still at an early stage in India, gaming is expected to take off on the smaller base with high potential for growth.

PROFITS ALL THE WAY

Just in terms of actual impact, nothing quite comes close to the Indian Premier League (IPL), a cricket tournament that debuted in 2008. India’s success in the T20 World Cup the preceding year was a trigger. Today, it is

**FIRST DECADE
OF 2000s**
SATELLITE
CHANNELS BEGAN
TO SPEND LARGE
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2000s
THE OVERSEAS
MARKET
COMPRISING NRIs
BECAME A HUGE
OPPORTUNITY IN
THIS DECADE

2018
SINCE THIS YEAR,
DIGITAL RIGHTS
HAVE OFTEN
COMMANDED
TWICE AS MUCH
AS SATELLITE
RIGHTS

2022
MULTIPLEXES ARE
THE NORM
IN LARGE CITIES
AND SEVERAL
SMALL CENTRES
AS WELL